Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Colossians

Colossians 1:1

Timothy was one of the closest co-workers of Paul. Their relationship was very strong. The work of Timothy was so important that Paul included him as a sender of this letter. He also included him in 2 Corinthians, Philippians, 1 and 2 Thessalonians, and Philemon.

Colossians 1:2

- Colossae was in the Lycus River valley in western Asia Minor. It was about 193 kilometers (120 miles) east of Ephesus and 16 kilometers (10 miles) southeast of Laodicea. Its place on an important Roman road exposed it to the social and religious trends of the time.
- brothers: Greek adelphoi, a term used for family members, both male and female.

Colossians 1:3–14

This section starts with a thanksgiving, common in New Testament letters. Paul thanks God for the growth of the faith of the Colossians. He prays they will understand it even more. Through this prayer, Paul shows his concern about the influence of false teachers.

Colossians 1:4

All the saints (meaning holy ones): The New Testament calls all Christians saints. They are set apart by God as his holy people (3:12).

Colossians 1:5

- The confident hope of the Colossian Christians provides a strong base for their faith and love (1:4).
- What God has reserved for believers has not yet been fully revealed, but it already exists in heaven.

Colossians 1:6

All over the world this gospel is bearing fruit and growing: The good news about Jesus is effective in changing lives and producing spiritual growth (compare 1:10).

Colossians 1:7

Epaphras probably became a Christian when Paul preached in Ephesus (see Acts 19:10; see also Colossians 4:12–13; Philemon 1:23). He then went back to Colossae to share the good news about Jesus with his own town.

Colossians 1:9–10

Paul prays that God would help his readers understand the the good news about Jesus better and its full expression in their lives. Spiritual growth leads to a clearer understanding of Christian truth and actions that please the Lord. This understanding gives believers the strength and patience to resist evil (1:11).

Colossians 1:12–13

- giving thanks to the Father: having humble gratitude to God for salvation gives powerful help to resist false teachings (see also 2:7; 3:17; 4:2).
- The inheritance is what God has promised his people (for example, see Deuteronomy 3:28; Psalm 33:12; Ezekiel 44:28). In the New Testament, the inheritance includes salvation and final rescue (see also Ephesians 1:11; Titus 3:7; Hebrews 9:15).

Colossians 1:15

- the image: In the Greek translation of the Old Testament, eikōn means “image” or “representation.” It describes humans as made in the image of God (Genesis 1:26–27). It also refers to the wisdom figure in Jewish writings (see Wisdom of Solomon 7:25–26). New Testament writers describe Christ as “the wisdom of God” to explain his importance (compare 1 Corinthians 1:24, 30).
- the firstborn over all creation: This phrase was important in early Christian debates about Christ’s nature. Firstborn does not mean God created him. It is a title from the Old Testament, showing supremacy in rank and priority in time (see, for example, Psalm 89:27).

Colossians 1:15–20

Paul describes Jesus as the ultimate creator and redeemer (1:15–17; 1:18–20). Three main things suggest these verses quote an early Christian hymn about Jesus:

1. These verses are brief statements.
2. These verses have contain high praise and special honor for Christ (he is exalted).
3. These verses use similar language and ideas.

Paul applied this hymn to the situation of the church in Colossae.

Colossians 1:16

- Thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities in the unseen world refer to different spiritual powers. This line emphasizes Christ’s supremacy over these

beings, who were getting a lot of attention from false teachers (see 2:18).
- All things were created through Him and for Him: Christ is both the creator of all things and the purpose of all creation.

Colossians 1:18

- Head of the body, the church: The Greek word kephalē (meaning "head") often has the sense of authority over or chief when Paul uses it as a metaphor (see also 2:10, 19; 1 Corinthians 11:3–10; Ephesians 4:15; 5:23).
- of the body: The metaphor of the church as Christ's body shows the essential unity of Christ and the church (see also Colossians 1:24; 2:19; 3:15; Ephesians 1:23; 2:16; 4:4, 12; 5:23, 30).
- firstborn from among the dead: See study note on Colossians 1:15.

Colossians 1:19

God, in all his fullness, shows that he has chosen to give a complete revelation of himself in Jesus Christ. By seeing and understanding Jesus, we also see and understand God (see John 14:6–11). Some false teachers claimed that Christians needed to seek other spiritual beings to learn more about God (see Colossians 1:16, 20). Yet, Christ alone is enough for all our knowledge of God (compare Colossians 2:8–9).

Colossians 1:20

Through Jesus Christ, God has made peace with everything. He has restored his control over all creation, in the spiritual places and on earth.

Colossians 1:21

The phrase alienated from God probably refers to their former status as Gentiles, who were not part of God's covenant people (see Ephesians 2:12).

Colossians 1:21–23

Paul shares the message of 1:15–20 with the Christians in Colossae. Since God has reconciled them, they now have a new spiritual status. They need to stay strong in the truth they have learned.

Colossians 1:22

The Colossians, like all believers, were considered holy and blameless by God. This was not due to their own perfection but because Christ's death reconciled them with God.

Colossians 1:23

proclaimed to every creature under heaven: Paul used hyperbole (exaggeration for emphasis) when he said the gospel has been proclaimed to every creature under heaven. He meant that key cities in the Roman world had established centers for spreading the good news about Jesus (see also 1:6).

Colossians 1:24

I fill up in my flesh what is lacking in regard to Christ's afflictions: Christ's suffering for redemption is unique and fully accomplished. Yet, he continues to suffer through his followers in a world opposed to the message of redemption. Christ and his church will keep suffering until God completes his purposes for this world (see also Mark 13:19–23; Romans 8:17–18; 1 Thessalonians 3:3).

Colossians 1:24–2.5

Paul considers his own role in the widespread preaching of the good news about Jesus (1:23).

Colossians 1:26

The idea of a hidden mystery... now revealed comes from Jewish apocalyptic beliefs. Jewish thinkers believed God's entire plan already existed in heaven. It remained hidden until God chose to reveal it. The good news, especially for non-Jews, remained secret until Christ revealed it.

Colossians 2:1–5

- Paul wants to build a stronger relationship with the Colossians, even though he has not met them. He also aims to correct false teachings that threaten their Christian community.
- Laodicea was 10 miles northwest of Colossae.

Colossians 2:2

the mystery of God: Christ himself is this plan (see 1:26).

Colossians 2:3

Paul expands on 1:15–20: Christ is all we need for spiritual understanding.

Colossians 2:6–15

Paul urges the Colossians to stay strong in their faith in Christ, despite the tempting arguments of the false teachers. For in Christ all the fullness of the Deity dwells in bodily form. Christ alone makes them complete.

Colossians 2:8

- philosophy: The Greek word philosophia included everything from Plato's ideas about existence to religious teachings of false religions. Paul does not criticize philosophy itself, but only empty philosophical ideas that oppose the good news.
- the spiritual forces of the world (also in 2:20): This phrase might refer to basic teachings common in this world (see Hebrews 5:12), or to spiritual beings believed to have powerful influence over historical events (see also Colossians 2:15, 20; Galatians 4:3).

Colossians 2:11

- the circumcision performed by Christ: Spiritual conversion to Christ is equivalent to physical circumcision to the body.
- the putting off of your sinful nature (literally the cutting away of the body of the flesh): Just as Jewish boys have their foreskin removed to join the people of God, believers have their metaphorical flesh (translated sinful nature) removed when they become Christians.

Colossians 2:12

Having been buried with Him in baptism: In a similar passage (Romans 6:3–6), Paul emphasizes the strong identity between believers and Christ. In God's view, we were truly with Him during his burial and resurrection. So we gain the benefits of his actions for us. Paul can connect this identification with Christ to baptism. This is because, in the early church, water baptism was closely related to conversion.

Colossians 2:14

the decrees that stood against us: The Greek phrase suggests a signed acknowledgment of debt. We cannot pay what we owe, so it stands against us. The law of God requires obedience that people cannot give. But God has forgiven our debt through the work of Christ (2:13).

Colossians 2:15

He made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them (literally he led [them] in a victory parade): The Roman army celebrated a big victory with a parade. The winning Roman general would lead the embarrassed captives into the conquered city. This image clearly pictures the great victory of God. Through the cross of Christ, God has defeated all hostile spiritual forces (see also Ephesians 4:7–11).

Colossians 2:16

- what you eat or drink: Many ancient religions had rules about what foods and drinks they allowed. The Old Testament does not prohibit alcohol, but some devout Jews chose not to drink it, especially those who lived in non-Jewish cultures (see Daniel 1:8–16).
- Many ancient religious groups, including Jews, held ceremonies to celebrate the new moon (see Numbers 10:10; Psalm 81:3; Isaiah 1:13).
- The Jewish Sabbath was part of the law of Moses and essential in Jewish religion. Christians could choose to observe the Sabbath, but Paul says they have the freedom to decide (see Romans 14:5). He said that forcing Sabbath observance is wrong. Observing the Sabbath was not necessary to express Christian devotion.

Colossians 2:16–23

Paul rejects the false teachers and their demands, explaining that their ideas come from human teachings (see 2:8). They advocated various rules of conduct that had no basis in Christ.

Colossians 2:17

The Old Testament ceremonies anticipated the coming of Christ, which Paul refers to as shadows (see also Hebrews 10:1).

Colossians 2:18

- the worship of angels: People in the first century were very interested in spiritual beings. Some Jews believed that angels were present with them during their times of worship, and some people might even have prayed to angels or worshiped them directly.
- The false teachers claimed to have had visions that made certain ceremonies necessary for the community.

Colossians 2:20

you have died with Christ: When Christ died on the cross, he defeated the spiritual powers (2:15). By sharing in his death, he frees us from the evil spiritual powers of the world (see 2:8).

Colossians 2:23

they are of no value: These rules come from the world, not from Christ (2:19). They cannot conquer a person's evil desires.

Colossians 3:1

strive for the things above: Christians live on earth, but their true selves have been raised with Christ.

This connects them to the spiritual world where Christ rules. In contrast, the commands and teachings of false teachers focus on earthly matters (2:22).

Colossians 3:1–11

Paul calls on the Colossians to adopt a new mindset that leads to a different way of living.

Colossians 3:3–4

- you died: See 2:20.
- What is now hidden will be revealed one day (compare 1:26). We cannot see Christ sitting at the right hand of God or that we have new life with Christ. But by faith in the good news, we know these things are true. When Christ returns in glory, everyone will see his supremacy. Then our relationship to him will become direct experience.

Colossians 3:5

- Put to death, therefore: We must truly die to this life by how we live each day (3:3) .
- greed, which is idolatry: Greedy people pursue money, sex, power, and possessions instead of God. They hope to find happiness in those things and treat them like idols.

Colossians 3:6

coming: Some manuscripts say coming on all who disobey him. In the Greek text, these words are exactly the same as in Ephesians 5:6. An early scribe might have added them here on purpose or by mistake.

Colossians 3:8

put aside (literally take off): Taking off clothes is a metaphor for removing habits that interfere with our relationship with the Lord (see Romans 13:12; Ephesians 4:22, 25; Hebrews 12:1; James 1:21; 1 Peter 2:1).

Colossians 3:9–10

the old self ... the new self: Paul contrasts old and new identities (see also Romans 5:12–21; 6:6; Ephesians 4:22–24). Believers stop living the way they used to and start living a new life in Christ, letting him be Lord and guide the way they live.

Colossians 3:11

barbarian, Scythian: The Greeks mocked people from other cultures for their inability to speak Greek well. They claimed those people could only say “bar bar” (which is where the word barbarian comes from). The Scythians were tribes on the north coast of the Black Sea, known for being fierce and crude (see Josephus, Against Apion 2.38). In the Christian faith, these kinds of differences between people groups do not matter. The Bible teaches that our relationship with God through Christ is more important than cultural differences or where we come from.

Colossians 3:12–17

Paul explains the new life of those who have been raised with Christ (3:1). Their good qualities and actions contribute to the peace and strength of the Christian community.

Colossians 3:15

Just as Christ is one, there can only be one body of Christ (see 1:18; Ephesians 4:4–6). Loyalty to Jesus as Lord should go beyond differences and lead to peace in our relationships.

Colossians 3:16

Psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs are for praise and worship (see 1 Corinthians 14:26; Ephesians 5:19). The book of Psalms serves as the original example.

Colossians 3:17

in the name of the Lord Jesus: In the Bible, a person’s name represents that person. To do something in the name of the Lord Jesus means to act in a way that aligns with his identity and authority.

Colossians 3:18

To submit means understanding your position below someone else in a society. This submission always suggests that God is at the top and his will is most important (see Acts 4:19–20; 5:29).

Colossians 3:18–4.1

This series of teachings is called a household code. Paul instructs wives (3:18), husbands (3:19), children (3:20), fathers (3:21), slaves (3:22–25), and masters (4:1). Similar codes are found in Greco-Roman writings and other parts of the New Testament (see Ephesians 5:22–6:9; 1 Peter 2:18–3:7).

Colossians 3:19

After instructing wives to submit to their husbands, the Paul encourages husbands to love their wives (see also Ephesians 5:25–30; 1 Peter 3:7).

Colossians 3:22–24

- Slaves have masters on earth they must obey. Slavery was central to life and the economy in the

ancient world. The New Testament does not directly oppose slavery. Yet, Christian faith creates relationships that change the nature of the social structure (see Philemon 1:15–16).
- It is the Lord Christ you are serving: All Christians, whether slave or free, serve a higher Master. His will is most important.

Colossians 4:1

Masters: Christian slave owners needed to understand that they were also slaves who had to obey Jesus Christ, their Master in heaven. He treats everyone with dignity and kindness.

Colossians 4:2

being watchful: The Greek verb for this phrase in the New Testament emphasizes the need for Christians to stay watchful because Christ will return (Matthew 24:42; 25:13; Mark 13:35, 37; 1 Thessalonians 5:6; Revelation 3:3; 16:15).

Colossians 4:2–6

New Testament letters often end by encouraging readers to pray and requests for their prayers.

Colossians 4:3

- God may open to us a door for the word: An open door symbolizes an opportunity to share the good news (see also Acts 14:27; 1 Corinthians 16:9; 2 Corinthians 2:12).
- the mystery of Christ: See Colossians 1:26–27; 2:2.
- for which I am in chains: Paul's commitment to spreading the good news led to his imprisonment (see Colossians Book Introduction, "Date and Occasion of Writing").

Colossians 4:5

redeeming the time (literally buy up the time): Just like people buy up a product at a good price, Christians should take advantage of every opportunity God gives them to share the good news and serve others.

Colossians 4:6

seasoned with salt: Salt is both a seasoning and a preservative (see Matthew 5:13). Paul might be encouraging Christians to speak to non-believers with well-chosen and appealing words. The Jewish rabbis sometimes referred to wisdom as salt, so Paul might also be urging Christians to speak wisely.

Colossians 4:7

Tychicus came from the province of Asia, where Colossae was (Acts 20:4). He worked with Paul especially in that area (Ephesians 6:21; 2 Timothy 4:12). Later, Paul sent him to assist Titus in Crete (Titus 3:12). Tychicus probably delivered this letter along with the letters known as Ephesians and Philemon.

Colossians 4:7–18

Most New Testament letters end with greetings and mentions of co-workers and travel plans. But this section of Colossians is longer than usual. Since Paul could not travel, he might have wanted the Colossians to stay connected with his co-workers. This would help them avoid being misled by false teachers.

Colossians 4:9

Onesimus was a runaway slave whom Paul sent back to his master, Philemon (see the book of Philemon).

Colossians 4:10

- Aristarchus was a common name, but he was probably the same man from Thessalonica who traveled with Paul to Rome (Acts 19:29; 20:4; 27:2). Acts does not mention Aristarchus was also arrested, so he might have chosen to stay in prison with Paul to support and help him.
- Mark the cousin of Barnabas joined Barnabas and Paul on their first missionary trip but left before it ended (Acts 13:13). This caused a disagreement between Paul and Barnabas before their second trip (Acts 15:37–40). Paul and Mark seem to have reconciled at some point (see also 2 Timothy 4:11; Philemon 1:24).
- You have already received instructions: There is no other record of this message.

Colossians 4:10–14

Out of the six people named, five are also mentioned in Philemon 1:23–24.

Colossians 4:11

Jesus, who is called Justus, appears only in this part of the New Testament. Paul uses the family name Justus because Jesus (meaning the Lord saves) was a common name among Jews in the first century.

Colossians 4:13

Laodicea and Hierapolis were the two most important cities in the Lycus River valley. Epaphras prayed for believers in Colossae and these nearby cities. This suggests that Epaphras was probably the first person

to share the good news about Jesus in all three of these cities.

Colossians 4:14

- Luke, the beloved physician, is famous for writing Acts and the Gospel of Luke. This verse is the only proof of two things about Luke: he was a doctor, and he was not a Jewish believer (see Colossians 4:10–11).
- Unlike the others mentioned in this passage, there are no details about Demas. Maybe Paul did not know him well. Demas later left Paul (2 Timothy 4:10).

Colossians 4:15

Nympha hosted a church in her home. In the first two centuries of the Christian church, most believers gathered for worship in private homes. We know nothing else about Nympha.

Colossians 4:16

make sure that it is also read: Over the years, people have tried to match the letter to the Laodiceans with a New Testament letter or fragment. Yet, Paul's letter to the church in Laodicea has probably been lost.

Colossians 4:17

Archippus (see also Philemon 1:2): We do not have any way of knowing more information about the work the Lord assigned to him.

Colossians 4:18

This greeting is in my own hand—Paul: The letter to the Colossians, like most ancient letters, was probably not written entirely by Paul himself. Instead, Paul likely spoke the words while a scribe wrote them down. This scribe is also called an amanuensis (a person trained to write neatly and clearly). To show that the letter was truly from him, Paul added his own greeting at the end in his own handwriting. This was his way of proving the letter was authentic and not a fake (compare Paul's comment in 2 Thessalonians 2:2).